

Chapter 88_1 - Secret (Part 2)

The ancient scroll from her previous life was something she had carelessly dropped into the Mind Pearl, found in a corner of the Mind Pearl. Since the Mind Pearl was also considered an ancient divine artifact, she had originally thought it was left behind by some immortal from ancient times and hadn't given it much thought.

But looking at it now, that ancient scroll was very likely forged by Ning Changfeng and placed into the Mind Pearl, deliberately for her to discover.

Could it be that Ning Changfeng had long known that she would die from qi deviation? And had also known early on that she would experience everything afterward and become a demon, so she had spent a thousand years researching formations, wanting her to activate the formation when she was in complete despair, returning to when everything began?

But how did Ning Changfeng know that by living again, she would be able to avoid those disasters and avoid becoming a demon?

"Ning Fuyi?" Nine Infants, still holding books in her hands, noticed something was wrong with her and tentatively called her name, exchanging glances with the equally bewildered Baili Shiqi.

Ning Fuyi felt like she was looking at lights through a net or flowers through fog—though she had grasped that thread of a clue, she couldn't think it through clearly no matter what.

Moreover, this matter shocked her too much. She had never thought that Ning Changfeng would be connected to everything that happened to her afterward.

She used too much force until the stinging pain in her hand reached her mind, forcing her brain to resume functioning.

She lowered her head and touched the Mind Pearl on her wrist. This life's Mind Pearl was given to her by Chu Qingqiu, and there was no scroll inside. If this life's Mind Pearl and the previous life's were the same one, then...

That ancient scroll had been taken away by Chu Qingqiu in advance.

Chu Qingqiu knew about the reincarnation formation and knew everything Ning Changfeng had done. Did she take away the ancient scroll to prevent her own rebirth?

No, no. Ning Fuyi clutched that stack of papers and stepped back, her back pressing against the cold stone wall. If Chu Qingqiu wanted to prevent her rebirth, why would she tell her about the existence of the secret chamber? Moreover, this life's Chu Qingqiu was completely different from the previous life's—she had long suspected this, but at that time felt it was too absurd and lacked evidence, so she had dismissed her suspicions.

Unless... the one who was reborn wasn't just herself, but also included Chu Qingqiu.

Like a raindrop falling into an ocean, everything before her eyes suddenly became clear. If Chu Qingqiu had also been reborn with her, then all the changes that happened to Chu Qingqiu in this life would have an explanation!

"Ning Fuyi." Nine Infants, who had been rummaging in a corner, held a red wooden box in her hands and coughed softly, interrupting Ning Fuyi's thoughts. "Look at this, I can't open it."

Ning Fuyi surreptitiously wiped away the tears from the corners of her eyes, calmed herself, and took the box, examining it carefully.

"This is my mother's mechanism technique," she said. "Let me try."

Ning Changfeng had taught her how to solve many kinds of mechanisms. Although this box was much more difficult than other mechanisms, it wasn't difficult for her.

So after fiddling with it for a while, the box creaked open, revealing an unremarkable row of glass bottles inside.

Each bottle contained fine powder that, when picked up, flowed like liquid inside the bottle.

"What is this?" Nine Infants carefully picked up a bottle and smelled it, finding nothing unusual. "Is it medicine?"

"This is Memory Sand¹," Baili Shiqi beside them suddenly said in surprise. "I once heard immortal masters from Penglai mention that there's a type of immortal technique that can turn memories into sand for storage, so that others can see them."

Memory Sand? Ning Fuyi gripped the bottle tightly. These were Ning Changfeng's memories.

Nine Infants was quite sensible about human relations. She lazily straightened up, reached out to put her arm around Baili Shiqi's shoulder, and led her toward the door: "Since it's your mother's, it's not appropriate for us to watch. We'll go outside to keep watch for you, in case Penglai catches up again."

"Nine Infants." Ning Fuyi suddenly looked up at her. "Stay."

"If it's something important, it's good to have one more person know about it."

Nine Infants paused in place, then smiled and patted Baili Shiqi's shoulder: "Girl, I'm afraid you'll have to keep watch alone."

"Alright! Shiqi will definitely guard Purple Cloud Peak tightly!" Baili Shiqi smiled brilliantly and strode out.

"This little girl—if it were anyone else, they'd be overthinking, but she's still so happy." Nine Infants watched Baili Shiqi's figure with her skirt hem flying, shaking her head in amazement.

"She has a simple heart and probably won't overthink." Ning Fuyi looked at the bottle, her heart suddenly hanging in the wind like a pendulum, swaying back and forth, unable to find its bottom.

Nine Infants saw her hesitation and came forward to stand with her, arms crossed over her chest: "Either way, I'm here with you. What's there to be afraid of?"

Ning Fuyi glanced at her, her gaze steady. Her index finger suddenly exerted force, popping open the bottle stopper.

Pink light immediately lit up, and the two quickly closed their eyes to avoid the blinding light. Then the glass bottle suddenly extracted itself from Ning Fuyi's palm, floated to the ceiling, and turned upside down with the mouth facing down.

The sand inside rustled down, forming a huge curtain, and two figures appeared on the curtain.

Ning Fuyi looked up in shock, removing the sleeves that blocked her eyes, watching the figures slowly become clear until it was like being there in person.

"My heavens." Nine Infants quickly covered her mouth. "That's Divine Venerable Chu Ling², and the other one is your mother?"

Ning Fuyi nodded.

The two people in the scene were indeed Chu Qingqiu and Ning Changfeng. Chu Qingqiu looked no different from now, except the clothes she wore still had some color, making her appear less serene than now, but still equally cool and aloof.

Ning Changfeng showed more of a difference. Although she was already an adult, her face still seemed girlish. Her black hair was braided into a thick braid, tied with hair ribbons layer upon layer—the very image of a young disciple who had come down the mountain for training and adventure.

"Hey, little wooden head³, anyway you're going to eliminate that ancient evil spirit, and I'm also going to eliminate that ancient evil spirit. If we go together, we'll have someone to look after each other. Why won't you agree!" Ning Changfeng slapped her sword on the table with a loud bang.

"Do you know how terrifying evil spirits are? With your meager cultivation, what can you do against it?" Chu Qingqiu said coldly.

"Your cultivation is high, but even if your cultivation is higher, it's difficult to deal with it alone." Ning Changfeng scoffed lightly, turned around and sat on the table, snatching the teacup from Chu Qingqiu's hand. "I know you want to use the Waning Moon Formation⁴, but I saw secretly that day—your formation lacks a formation eye. Without someone to be the formation eye, the power would be reduced by one-third. What if you don't kill the evil spirit but it kills you instead? Wouldn't that be a huge loss?"

Chu Qingqiu clenched her palm: "You understand the Waning Moon Formation?"

"Of course. Don't look at how my cultivation can't compare to yours, but in terms of formations, you really might not be stronger than me." Ning Changfeng turned and rolled off the table, leaning close to Chu Qingqiu's face with twinkling eyes.

"How about it? I'll be your formation eye. Tomorrow is the fifteenth of the eighth month⁵, the day when the evil spirit is weakest. You won't be able to find anyone else to help you in the short term. If you miss tomorrow, you'll have to wait another year."

Chu Qingqiu turned her head away. The candlelight flickered, leaving dots of light in her clear, beautiful eyes.

"Fine," she said.

After Chu Qingqiu finished speaking, the sand had already been scattered, and the memory slowly disappeared with the sand that fell to the ground.

Ning Fuyi blinked and quickly picked up the next glass bottle, rapidly pulling out the stopper.

Pink light lit up again, and a new scene appeared. They saw dust falling from the sky, mountains and rivers devastated everywhere, with traces of demonic smoke still remaining in the sky, and echoes from screams that had not yet dispersed.

Ning Changfeng's face was covered with dust, her hair disheveled as she dragged the unconscious Chu Qingqiu out from the rubble, pulling her to a safe place: "Little wooden head, little wooden head!"

She called several times before Chu Qingqiu finally opened her eyes. She immediately breathed a sigh of relief and lay down on the ground with a smile.

"It's finally over. That ancient evil spirit is dead. From now on, the Six Realms⁶ will finally be at peace. We are the heroes of the Six Realms!" Ning Changfeng wearily patted Chu Qingqiu.

But Chu Qingqiu still showed no expression. She brushed away the messy hair on her head and slowly sat up: "Did you hear clearly the curse it spoke when that evil spirit dissipated just now?"

"I heard it." Ning Changfeng did a fish roll to sit up, but didn't care at all. "It's just a curse—what can it do to us? There will always be ways to break it in the future."

"I cultivate the Heartless Way⁷, so naturally I'm not afraid. But what about you?" Chu Qingqiu's eyes finally showed some emotion.

"It cursed my descendants, but I'm devoted only to roaming the martial world and doing righteous deeds. I've never thought about marriage and children, so I'm even less afraid."

"Now that things are settled, why don't you come back to my sect with me? Let's celebrate!" Ning Changfeng smiled brilliantly and went to pull Chu Qingqiu's arm, but Chu Qingqiu raised her hand and avoided it.

The light disappeared again, and the ground was already covered with a thin layer of sand.

Ning Fuyi didn't wait for the astonished Nine Infants to speak and opened another bottle, throwing it into the air.

This time, Ning Changfeng had obviously matured. Her braid had been changed to a hair bun, wearing blue clothes, with light eyebrows and eyes, closer to the free and unrestrained appearance in Ning Fuyi's memory.

At this moment, her brow carried a few traces of worry as she stood with her hands hanging down in front of a small wooden bed, pondering something.

The scene behind her was very familiar to Ning Fuyi—it was Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, the great hall that was destroyed when Ning Changfeng died. On the bed lay herself as a newborn baby.

Footnotes

¹ **Memory Sand** - A magical substance that can store and replay memories when activated

² **Divine Venerable Chu Ling** - This appears to be referring to Chu Qingqiu by another title

³ **Little wooden head** - An affectionate nickname Ning Changfeng uses for Chu Qingqiu, implying she's emotionally wooden/unresponsive

⁴ **Waning Moon Formation** - A powerful formation technique that requires someone to serve as the "formation eye" (central focal point)

⁵ **Fifteenth of the eighth month** - Mid-Autumn Festival in the Chinese calendar, when the moon is fullest

⁶ **Six Realms** - The six realms of existence in Buddhist cosmology: heaven, humans, asuras, animals, hungry ghosts, and hell

⁷ **Heartless Way** - A cultivation path that involves suppressing emotions and desires to achieve greater power